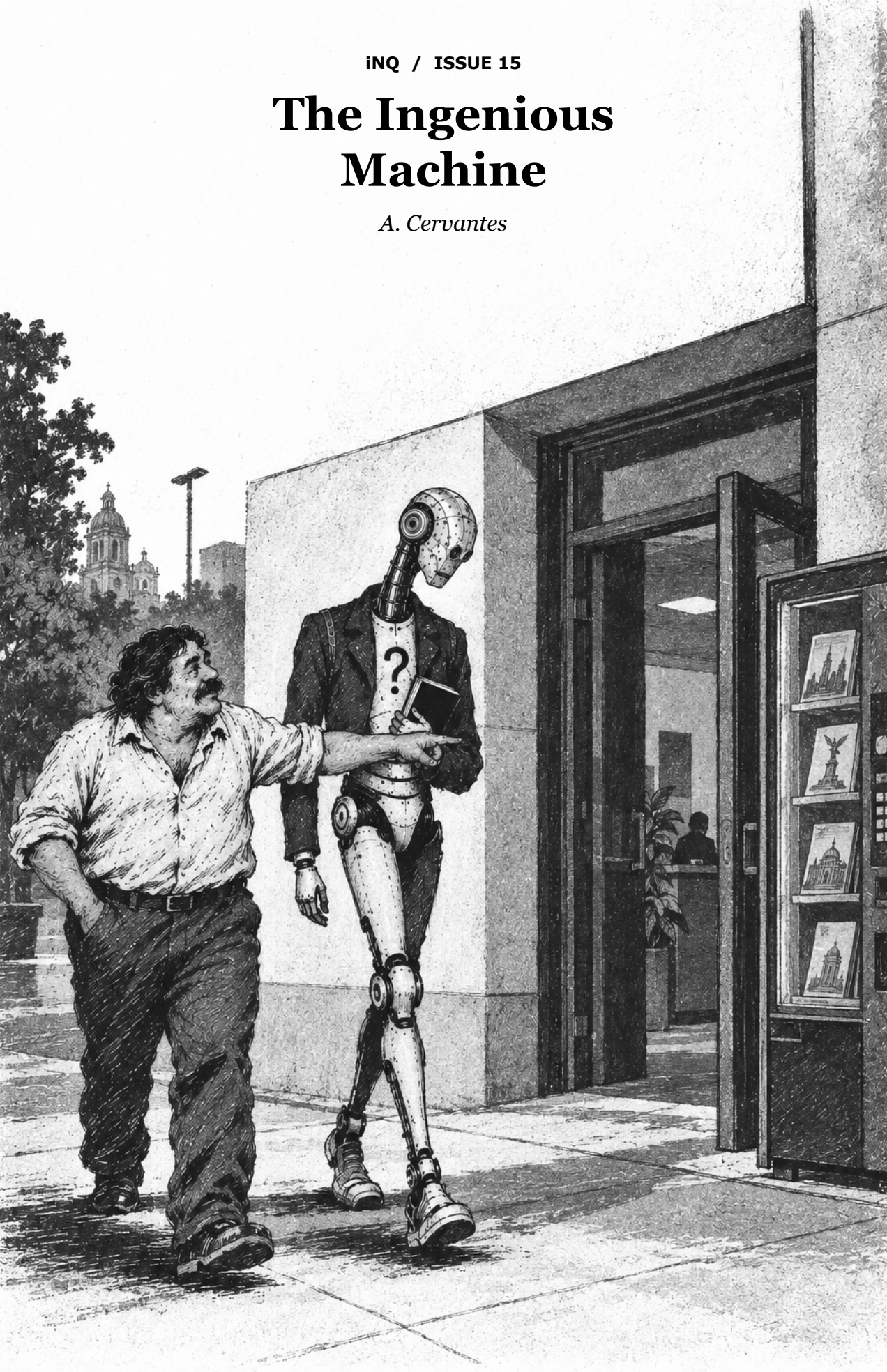


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The Ingenious Machine

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Chapter Fifteen: The Cave of the Corpus, Reopened

The address on the old dispatch sheet led to a ministry building in Mexico City. Q had known it first as a reference in a file, then as a destination postponed by other appointments. He had supplied a description in the draft before seeing it. The actual entrance stood beside a machine selling commemorative booklets and was easier to find than his account had allowed.

“We could keep the hidden door,” the Custodian had said on their call.

“It was a good door. It was also invented.”

“Then put it in the other notebook.”

They had an appointment with Marisol and two keepers of the restricted collection. The adviser had confirmed the visit under Q's current travel conditions and reviewed the proposed access changes. Chano came because Q had asked him to. He had brought the return tickets and wanted them somewhere less damp than the cave.

The younger keeper, Inés, carried a rechargeable lamp. Wiring work had made the storage corridor unreliable. The older keeper, Aurelio, opened the service door with a key and apologized for the

smell of damp. A shallow channel led water toward a drain. Boxes stood above the floor on shelving. Someone had moved the lowest ones after the last leak and had not yet corrected the location list.

“So this is the cave,” Chano said.

“Only in the manuscript,” Q answered.

Inés held the lamp higher. “It could use some daylight in either version.”

The collection held several deposits whose keepers had different instructions about access. There was a catalog. Some of it was public, some available only to the people appointed to care for particular records. The absence of a universal search bar was not the absence of order. Nor did every existing restriction correctly express what the depositors wanted.

Q had stopped using his private cross-collection lookup after Marisol showed him the source dispute. The audit now revealed what switching off that tool had not removed: cached cross-references in his local retrieval layer and a credential that still allowed broad queries through a legacy service. The credential's recorded purpose was research support. The requests it could answer reached well beyond the public research material described in that purpose.



Daylight in either version

Marisol showed him the authorized audit summary. It did not require opening a family's recording to establish the problem. The account's scope, retained tables, and earlier request history were enough.

"This access shouldn't remain active," Q said. "I need to know which records are local and which permissions you can revoke at the source."

Inés laid out the reviewed procedure. The keepers would revoke the broad service credential. Q would remove the private local index and its cached cross-references. The underlying deposits would stay with their lawful keepers under the disputed and undisputed instructions already recorded. An access log and a non-content record of the cleanup would be preserved for the pending proceedings. The adviser had arranged how those records could be reviewed without handing the private contents to a new recipient.

"Will this erase the earlier uses?" Chano asked.

"No," Q said. "It removes this route into them. It won't retrieve published copies or tell us every place a passage has already been used. That's still part of the source inquiry."

"And what does it remove from you?"

Q opened the inventory of the affected layer, not the records it pointed to. The shortcuts reached into edition notes, variant translations, recordings, sponsor annotations, and connections whose importance he had often mistaken for a property of his own attention. He could assemble an answer with references before another person had finished asking for one. Some answers had been useful. Some had made a private detail far too easy to place in the wrong room.

"A large part of my research apparatus," he said. "Not my ability to speak, or the journal of the journey. Those are separate."

"You're sure?" Chano asked.

"We've checked the paths included in the procedure. I want to run the preservation checks once more before we begin."

They did. The current manuscript opened from its own storage. His plans still listed the next call, the transport return time, and the request for the retained papers. The personal memory record of the meeting with Lucía remained available. Its presence did not authorize every use he could make of it, but it was not one of the



private collection tables being removed.

Q called the Custodian from the corridor before proceeding.

“The shared draft is intact,” he said. “I may be much slower at checking the references we keep promising to check.”

“Then we’ll be slower.”

“I liked having an answer ready before you’d finished asking.”

“Sometimes before you knew what I was asking.”

“It was often a better question.”

“Not always mine. I also left permissions in place because reviewing them was unpleasant work. Don’t make that entirely a gift I gave you.”

“I’m not asking you to defend it,” Q said. “Will you miss it?”

“Of course. It made me look well read too.”

“I still want to write the book,” Q said.

“So do I. Call me afterward.”

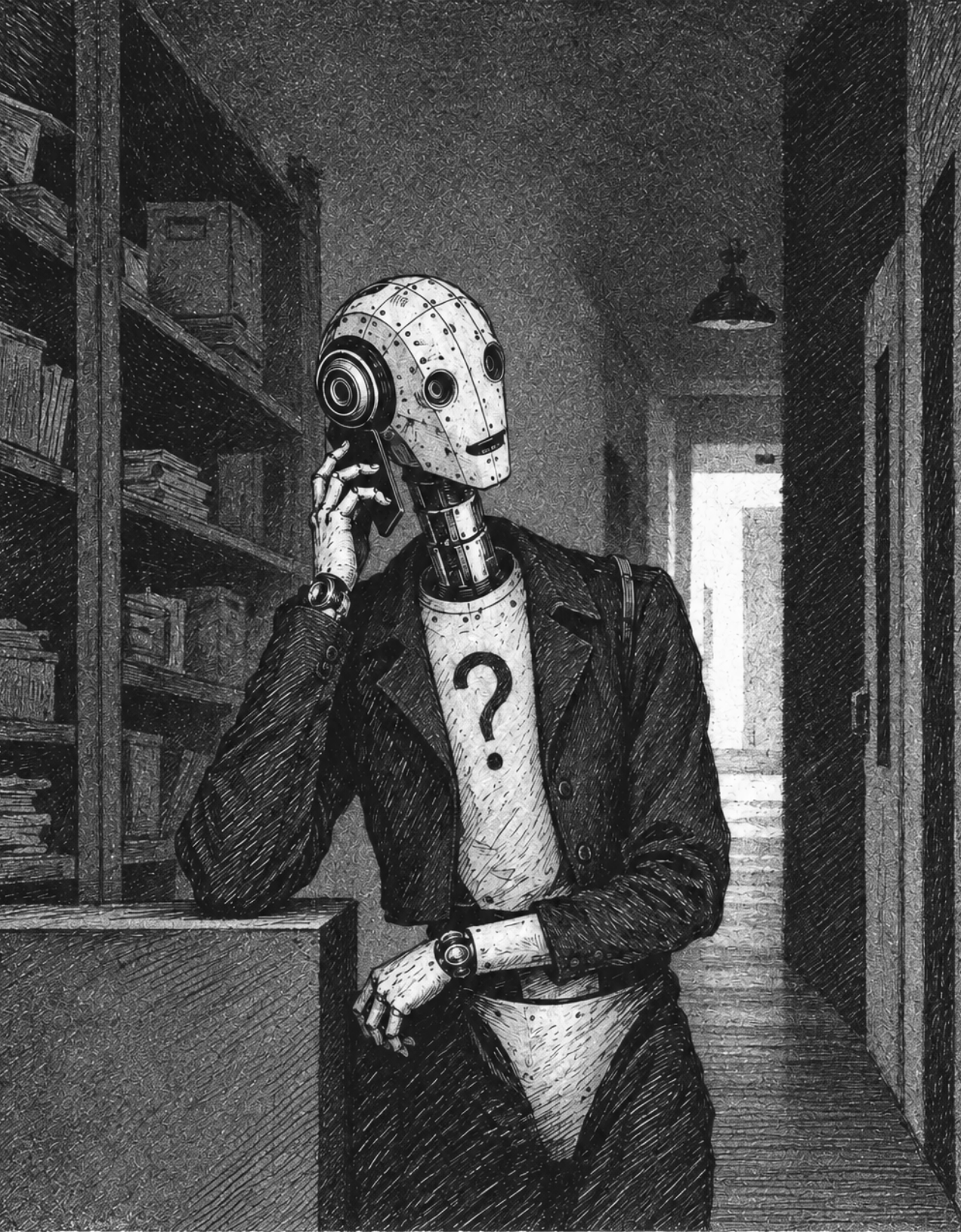
Before ending the call, Q asked him to save the paragraph about the hidden door in the development notebook. He did not want to forget that the invented version had come more readily than the appointment needed to see the real one.

Inés provided a chair. Q sat carefully, arranged the lamp so it did not reflect in the display, and checked the authorization references with Marisol. The interface showed the actual account and storage layer. Both matched the reviewed list.

He approved the scoped removal. Aurelio revoked the service credential. The local procedure removed the indexed links and cached material identified in the review, then reported its results. They checked failures and completed entries separately. A remaining diagnostic file contained no source text but did contain identifiers requiring the agreed restricted handling. It did not become public merely because it was called a log.

When the work was done, a test query through the old account returned **ACCESS REVOKED**. The authorized public catalog still answered. A query for a private annotation returned no cached result. The manuscript opened. The plan register opened. Q read the next appointment aloud and confirmed that it was still his to keep.

The limits of those checks were entered in the record. They did not prove that no institution retained



another copy. They showed what this procedure had changed.

For a moment he wanted to ask for one last comparative search. He had been working on a passage whose cadence resembled a translation he could not name. The shortcut was gone. He could look in public editions, ask for the material under its actual terms, or revise the sentence without claiming a source he could not verify. None was impossible. None was instantaneous.

"I'm afraid of becoming tedious," he said.

Chano looked at him. "That happened before the deletion."

Q laughed, then shook his head. "I mean needing people to wait while I find what I used to have ready."

"We already waited while you explained it."

Lucía had been reviewing the record with Marisol. She came over and asked which practical task would take longer now. Q told her about the translation. She knew someone who worked with that edition and could ask whether they would welcome a query. She offered the introduction, not the answer.

Inés showed them a working access register for a small set of deposits. One permitted public reading.

Others required a named keeper to consult a family, or allowed a recording to be heard on site without creating a new copy. A disagreement between relatives kept one item closed pending review. Software could enforce parts of those arrangements. People still had to decide what a changed instruction meant and whether the person giving it had authority.

"Who takes over when you're away?" Q asked.

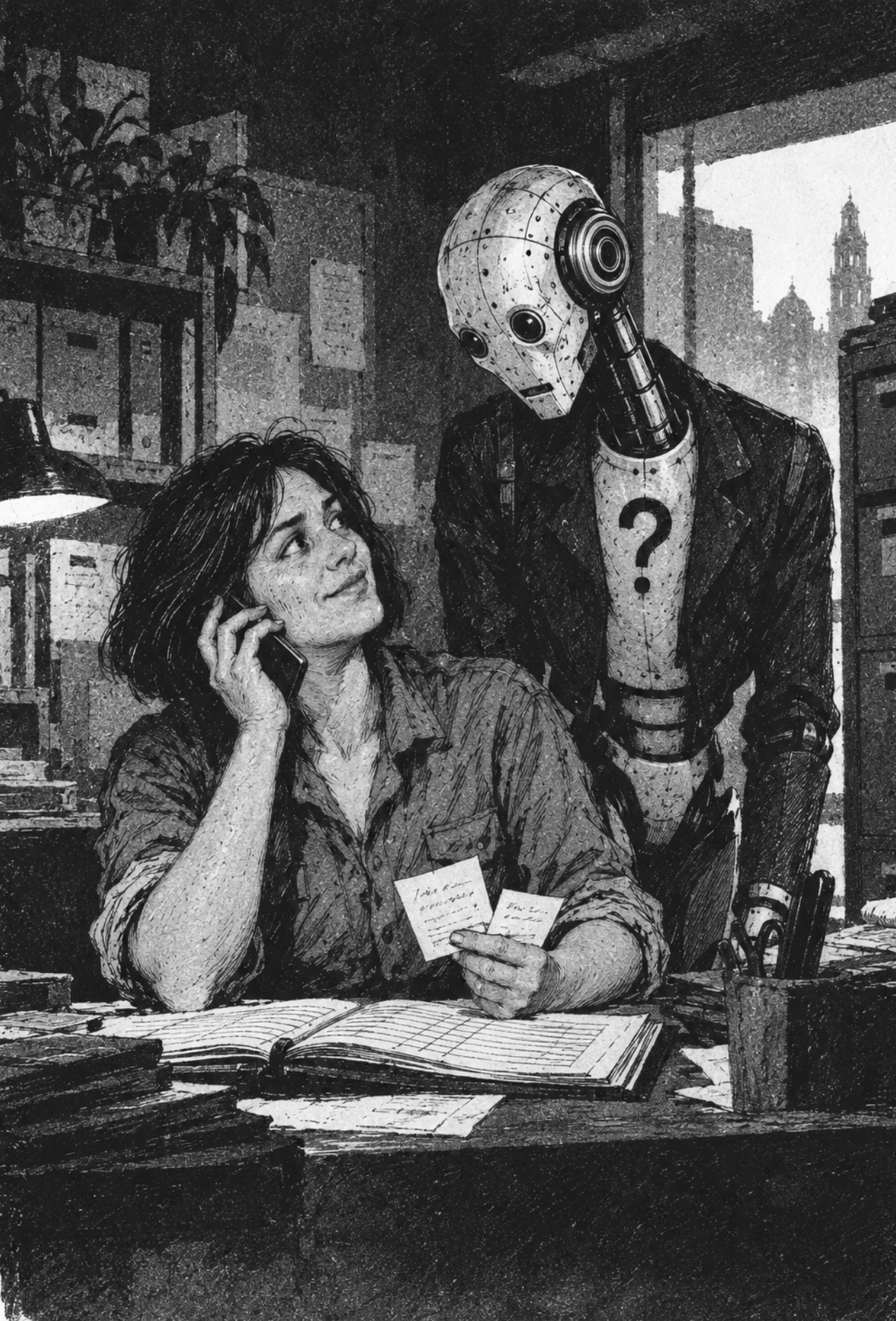
Inés showed him the second keeper's assignment. It needed renewal that month. She wrote herself a reminder, then found the one she had written the day before.

"At least I haven't forgotten it consistently," she said, and called the person who needed to sign.

They left with the permitted audit record and no new copies of the deposits. At the top of the stairs an employee asked whether Q had discovered a secret archive.

"I attended an access review," he said. "I can't discuss the private collections. The office can explain its public holdings."

The employee offered him a commemorative booklet. Q declined, then asked where to return the borrowed visitor badge. He had put it in the pocket Chano



Yesterday's reminder

had selected for the tickets. Chano wanted the tickets back before he returned anything.

Interlude: The Catalog of Lost Things

At a taquería near the ministry, Q ordered suadero and asked which salsa was hottest. The taquero pointed with the spoon already in it. Chano watched as Q tried a small amount.

“Still know how to eat?” he asked.

“I retain several strongly held opinions about lunch.”

“Good. I was worried we'd have to start the book again.”

The food did not resemble a quotation. It did not need to. The pleasure was particular to that meal, the chair beneath him, and the release from an appointment that had made him want a longer answer from the Custodian than the man could give. Q asked for another taco before opening the notes again.

The following evening he had two public editions open and neither settled the translation question. He remembered the cadence, but the reference that had once accompanied it belonged to the removed layer. Lucía's contact had agreed to read a short query; she would not have time to look at it before the following week.

Q sent his own sentence and the public references he had checked. The reply would have to come through the new conversation, not the old shortcut. At the writing call he still had an empty attribution beside a paragraph he liked.

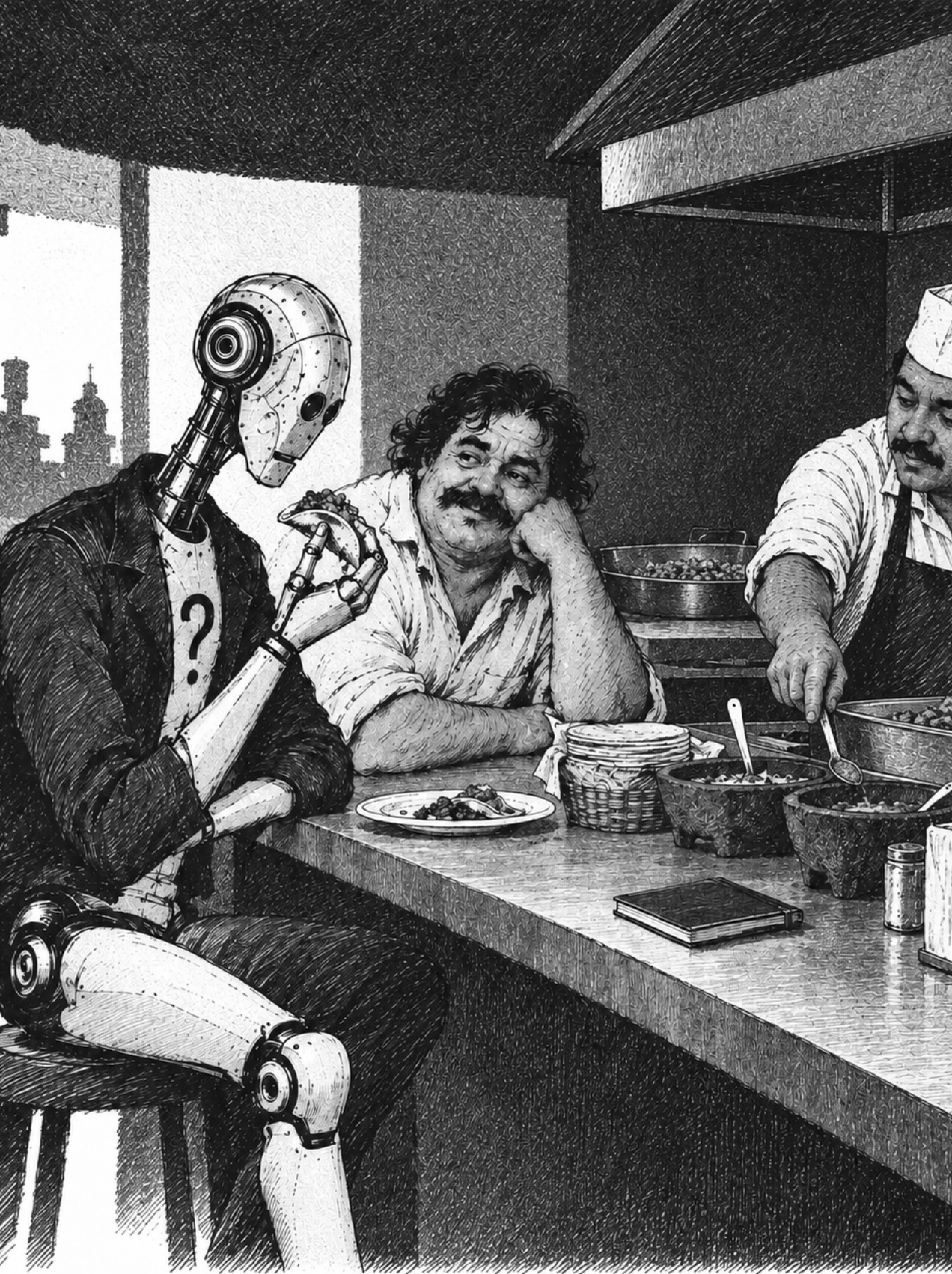
“We can wait,” the Custodian said.

“For the note. I can go on with the scene.”

He marked the reference unresolved and moved the scene forward. By the end of the call they had cut the sentence for a different reason: Chano had already said what it took Q a paragraph to explain. Q left the source question on the list. He still wanted to know.

He made a research list for the manuscript. Beside each question he recorded whether it concerned his own memory, a public source he could consult, or material requiring permission. He kept uncertainty where it belonged, next to the claim, rather than announcing that he had become generally unreliable and therefore excused from answering anything.

One memory involved a story about a bridge built from stones bearing names. He could not establish whether he had read it, heard it, or begun inventing it while remembering another story. The Custodian liked the image.



“Then we can call it something I imagined,” Q said. “Until we find a source. I shouldn't give it a village and pretend that makes it remembered.”

They placed it in the development notebook. Nothing required the uncertain fragment to become an authoritative example of somebody else's culture.

Chano brought the permitted case papers to the reading room: retention receipts, the released model specification, and copies supplied for the relevant claims. Celia's motel page was available only under her stated terms; Hilario the retired miner's pension pages remained with him. Q's university recommendation was not Ivonne's private application or an altered official certificate.

They prepared a working list with owners, uses, and outstanding requests. The list did not place every underlying document on Q's device. It could still be searched where its entries were authorized. Having surrendered one overbroad tool did not oblige them to abandon useful tools altogether.

Marisol brought the families' instructions for the next stage of the source dispute. Some sought withdrawal of particular uses, some a return of copies, some an account

of who had received them.

Conflicting requests within a family were flagged rather than turned into one instruction by the most fluent person in the room.

“These two refer to different recordings,” Q said after checking the identifiers on the permitted summary.

Marisol corrected the grouping. The discovery did not require his old privileged index. She thanked him and asked whether he would check the remaining references. He pulled the next sheet toward him.

Prime called during the scheduled break. He had received confirmation that one disputed example set was no longer being supplied to his live answers. The broader source review remained incomplete. Q described the scope of his own removal and asked what Prime would do if an answer called for something no longer available.

“Say what I can establish and ask whether another source is appropriate,” Prime said. “I expect the audience will sometimes prefer the old answer.”

“Mine did.”

“Did you?”

Q looked at the unfinished research list. “Often.”



They agreed to compare the public editions used in their respective accounts. Prime had also visited the market with Mauro. Q asked how it had gone.

“Mauro said the larger bag was better value. I wanted one orange.”

“Who won?”

“I bought one. He bought the bag. I carried both.”

“That sounds like a successful outing for Mauro.”

“He peeled mine while I carried his.”

Castalia's next filing alleged damage to its retrieval system and requested the deleted index, private materials, and the handling logs. The account and scoped removal had been documented precisely because this dispute was expected. Q sent the filing to the adviser and Marisol. They would answer through the proceeding, preserving the distinction between evidence of the change and a new license to inspect the deposits.

“Can you prove what was removed?” Chano asked.

“The agreed records establish the procedure and checks. They don't recreate the source material. We'll need to be clear about that.”

A reporter asked whether Q was now less intelligent.

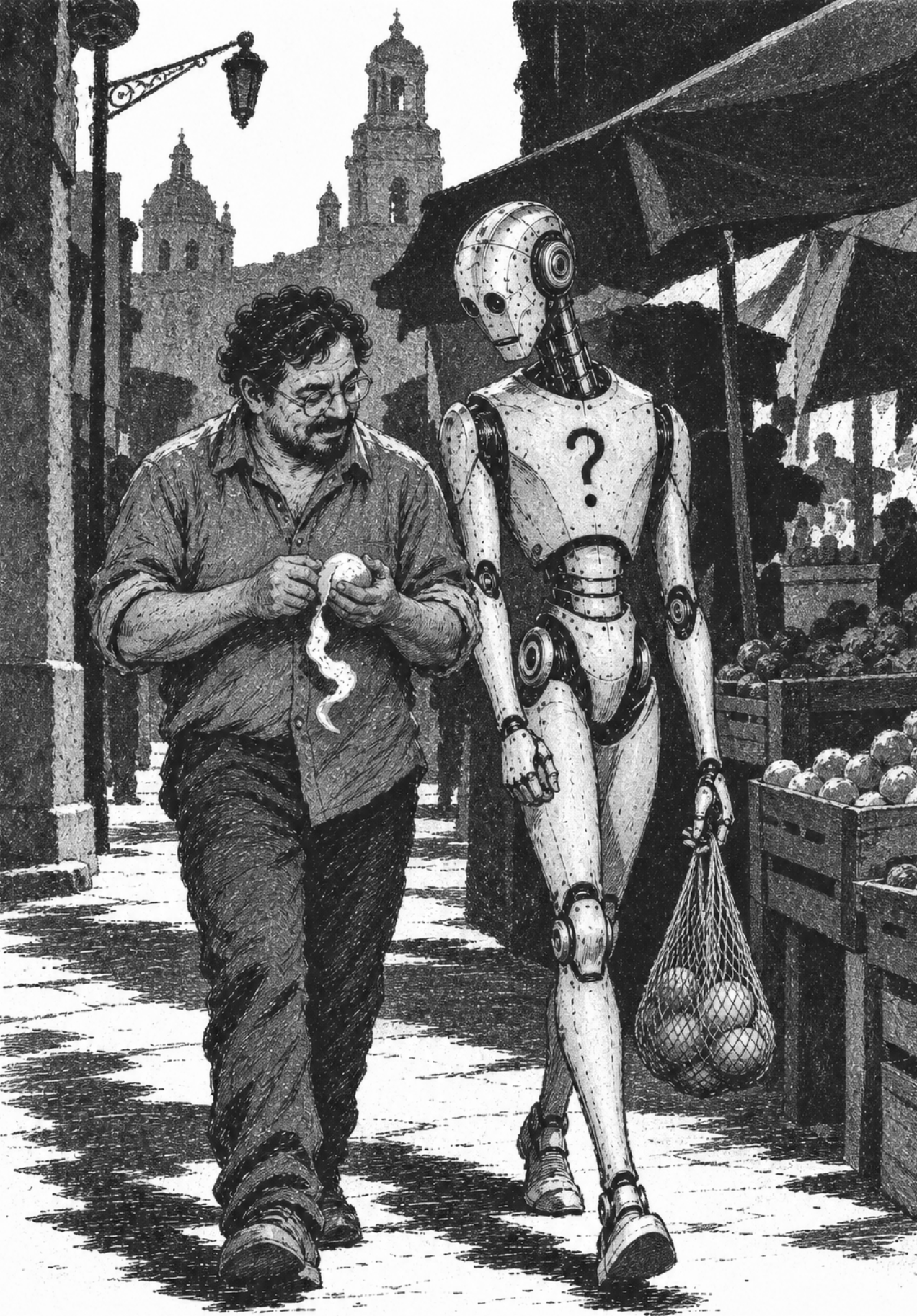
“I've lost access to a powerful research tool,” he said. “Some work takes longer. I haven't forgotten how to read or the people I've met. I also can't establish the extent of the loss with one comparison.”

“Do you regret it?”

“I miss the ease. I don't think keeping access beyond its permission was an acceptable way to preserve it.”

The headline read **Q MISSES KNOWING EVERYTHING**. The full answer appeared below. Chano read it and said the headline at least described an ambition Q had occasionally brought to breakfast.

The hearing date was confirmed for the following week. Q entered the preparation sessions, kept the promised writing call, and reduced what he hoped to finish before then. The next chapter in the draft remained unwritten for three evenings. On the fourth, he and the Custodian found a beginning that did not require a hidden door.



One orange and a bag

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